

Reflections on the Tairan & Weng Jiayi Video Podcast

I first noticed the podcast featuring Tairan and the legendary Weng Jiayi about a month ago. At the time, I only skimmed through some clips, but today I finally found the time to listen to the entire episode. Here are my takeaways.

Listening to this podcast, I felt a strong resonance with several views I've written about before—such as the encouragement of exploration and how the environment shapes one's mental model, which in turn dictates destiny. One point of divergence, however, is that Jiayi leans toward pure determinism, believing the future is already set. In contrast, I believe in human agency: we can recognize the flaws in our environment-induced mental models and correct them through deliberate practice.

Jiayi is an extraordinary creator and engineer. His background is classic "top-tier"—from NOI (Olympiad in Informatics) to Tsinghua and then CMU. But to me, the most critical factor in his massive success was his **choices**. While his talent raised his ceiling, luck and timing played huge roles. As mentioned in the podcast, he was focused on RL (Reinforcement Learning) infrastructure long before anyone knew RL would play such a pivotal role in LLMs. During the strictest period of pandemic control, he chose to go to CMU for his Master's and then joined OpenAI when it had fewer than 300 people. In hindsight, this was a perfect move—catching the wind right as it turned into a hurricane.

The lesson here is: Choice is everything. But we shouldn't treat choices as "gambles." Instead, we should strive for deep insights into the future to make the "right" move.

On Career Paths: Academia vs. Industry

If the goal is industry, Jiayi made an excellent point: **It is much easier to teach an engineer to be a researcher than to teach a researcher to be an engineer.** A Master's degree combined with strong side-projects (like high-star GitHub repos) can grant you the same—or even higher—leverage as a PhD, with significantly less risk.

If the goal is academia, one must be cautious about pursuing a PhD in "hot" fields. By the time you finish in five years, those currently "eating the meat" will have already occupied all the key positions. The core of a PhD is the connection with a top-tier advisor and betting on a direction you believe will *start* to explode five years from now (like World Models, though that remains debatable).

On Engineering and "Demystifying" Technology

Engineering capability is #1. In today's AI era, which is essentially an **experimental science**, ideas are cheap, but validation requires powerful engineering.

Another point I deeply agree with is Jiayi's disdain for public evaluation systems (like GPA). He built his own **private evaluation system**—competitions, papers, and GitHub stars. When a metric becomes a goal, it ceases to be a good metric. A person's success is determined by:

1. **Choice**
2. **Connections**
3. **A Correct Internal Evaluation System**

As a junior in college, I feel this deeply. Even Tsinghua elites have to balance their time; Jiayi's approach of giving GPA just enough effort to be "sufficient" and no more is exactly how I operate.

On Open Source and the Reality of Research

Every mentor I respect emphasizes the same thing: **Open Source**. Creating output and contributing to open source is one of the highest ROI activities you can do. Jiayi hinted at the chaos within the research community. As a pragmatist and a creator, I share his view: 90% of papers are noise. He predicts the academic world will be restructured, and while I haven't experienced grad school yet, I resonate with his pursuit of efficiency and impact.

The "Moat" is Not Technology

Technical people need to **"demystify" technology**. The reason OpenAI needs a CEO like Sam Altman is because you need someone to manage the organization, manage the context, and—most importantly—**discover demand**. The smell for market needs is far more important than the code.

As a creator, products and open-source projects are what I truly value. Interestingly, with the rise of LLMs, algorithm roles might be the first to be replaced, while system roles remain robust. AI has turned algorithms into a "brute-force" experimental game, but the bottleneck is the iteration speed of the system. Even with "Vibe Coding," system-level code often remains out-of-distribution for LLMs, whereas ideas can now be mass-generated and verified.

On AI Agents: The "Super Regex"

The hyped concept of "AI Agents" is, in essence, **Traditional Software Engineering (SE) with an added "Super Regex"**—one that is probability-based and supports natural language. It's the ability to extract structured information from fuzzy, dynamic language.

The difficulty in building Agents today isn't the "new" concepts; it's the age-old problems of SE. The gap between Agents is a gap in SE fundamentals. MCP (Model Context Protocol) is just providing specialized "regex" tools and capabilities. Understanding this leads to two emotions:

1. **Demystification:** "Oh, it's just this?"
2. **Awe:** "But this is already profoundly powerful."

Conclusion

We must ignore the "Contempt Hierarchy" (the elitism between different technical fields). Whether you are training models, doing context engineering, or building systems, reaching the top of any field is valuable.

But we must stay sober: **Technology is never the moat for an internet company**. The only moats are **Ecosystem, Data, and Traffic**. Recognizing that technology is "just" a tool—and not a sacred pedestal—is the fundamental step in evolving from a pure technician to a true Creator.